Reality is an aspect of property. It must be seized. And investigative journalism is the noble art of seizing reality back from the powerful. By the time WikiLeaks was up and running and making headlines, much of this had been forgotten, or had not occurred to a new generation of journalists or readers. We made it our task to revivify the art of observation. With all due modesty, I think we became the first intelligence agency of the people. And those early, heady days, only four years ago in real time, but a different era to us, were filled with a sense that we would spill over borders and prejudices, including our own, and get better by the month. We still had a lot to learn. But the principles of good journalism in service of better governance would remain undiluted from those days to these.

The African experience was filtered through this period, but I want to relate that experience in the next chapter. The day before leaking the equipment list for Iraq, we hit a home run by publishing the manual for Guantánamo Bay. It's an incredible modern document, something that one can imagine being read in hundreds of years' time by people who want to understand the ideological struggles of our period. Not just ideological struggles, either, but mental ones. Its classification was low, so clearly the authorities never expected this manual to be read by anyone outside the prison camp, and isn't that part of the problem with secret documents? They are often written by people with a heavy bias, an almost fetishistic hatred, and with a deep wish to inculcate that bias in their colleagues. The Guantánamo manuals cover all the main aspects of how detainees are brought to the installation, how they are to be kept, and what should happen to them. It reads like something taken in dictation for Attila the Hun or Vlad the Impaler: relentlessly cruel, dehumanising, paranoid, dramatic and excessive, it would make even the sleepiest tax-payer wonder what fundamental weakness, what fatal need, was being addressed by this manual and this crazy detention centre, all paid for in tax dollars.

The manual relates how records should be faked to hide prisoners from the Red Cross. It states that all prisoners will be placed in maximum security for their first month after arrival, to soften them up for interrogation. 'The two week period following Phase 1 will continue the process of isolating the detainee and fostering dependence on the interrogator.' It outlines the whole aggressive mindset of the Quick Response Force (QRF), the unit on permanent standby in case of 'a disturbance in the Detention Facility'. How the prisoners could ever cause